

quality products, but only in service of the goal of winning over customers. We must be willing to set aside our traditional professional standards to start the process of validated learning as soon as possible. But once again, this does not mean operating in a sloppy or undisciplined way. (This is an important caveat. There is a category of quality problems that have the net effect of slowing down the Build-Measure-Learn feedback loop. Defects make it more difficult to evolve the product. They actually interfere with our ability to learn and so are dangerous to tolerate in any production process. We will consider methods for figuring out when to make investments in preventing these kinds of problems in [Part Three](#).)

As you consider building your own minimum viable product, let this simple rule suffice: remove any feature, process, or effort that does not contribute directly to the learning you seek.

SPEED BUMPS IN BUILDING AN MVP

Building an MVP is not without risks, both real and imagined. Both can derail a startup effort unless they are understood ahead of time. The most common speed bumps are legal issues, fears about competitors, branding risks, and the impact on morale.

For startups that rely on patent protection, there are special challenges with releasing an early product. In some jurisdictions, the window for filing a patent begins when the product is released to the general public, and depending on the way the MVP is structured, releasing it may start this clock. Even if your startup is not in one of those jurisdictions, you may want international patent protection and may wind up having to abide by these more stringent requirements. (In my opinion, issues like this are one of the many ways in which current patent law inhibits innovation and should be remedied as a matter of public policy.)

In many industries, patents are used primarily for defensive purposes, as a deterrent to hold competitors at bay. In such cases, the patent risks of an MVP are minor compared with the learning benefits. However, in industries in which a new scientific